

Glossary of Key Terms: Heuristic Evaluation and Usability

Usability

How easy, efficient, and satisfying a system is to use.

Example

A banking app that users can learn quickly and use without confusion.

Usability Problem

A design issue that makes a system difficult or confusing to use.

Example

Buttons with unclear labels.

Evaluation

The process of testing and examining a system to identify usability problems and improve the design.

Example

Testing a shopping website to see whether users can easily buy products.

Cognitive Walkthrough

A usability evaluation method where evaluators examine step-by-step how users complete tasks.

The goal is to see whether users can understand and use the system easily.

Example

Checking whether a new user can successfully upload a video to YouTube.

Heuristic

A general usability guideline or rule of thumb used to evaluate designs.

Example

“Provide clear feedback to users.”

Heuristic Evaluation

A usability inspection method where experts examine a user interface using usability principles called heuristics.

Example

Experts reviewing a website to identify navigation and design problems.

Multiple Evaluators

Using several experts during heuristic evaluation because different people discover different problems.

Example

One evaluator may notice navigation issues while another notices unclear labels.

Observer

A person who records notes and observations during evaluation sessions.

Example

Writing down usability problems discovered by evaluators.

Pre-evaluation Training

Preparation given to evaluators before the evaluation begins.

This includes:

- task information,
- system background,
- and evaluation goals.

Severity Rating

A score showing how serious a usability problem is.

Severity Levels

Rating Meaning

- | | |
|---|------------------|
| 0 | Not a problem |
| 1 | Cosmetic problem |

Rating Meaning

- 2 Minor problem
- 3 Major problem
- 4 Serious usability catastrophe

Debriefing

A discussion session after evaluation where evaluators and designers review usability problems and possible solutions.

Example

A design team meeting to discuss how to fix identified interface problems.

User Testing

A usability evaluation method involving real users performing tasks on a system.

Example

Watching users try to book airline tickets on a website.

Interaction Flow

The sequence of steps users follow while completing a task.

Example

Searching for a product → adding to cart → making payment.

Task

An activity users try to complete using a system.

Example

Uploading a video or purchasing a product online.

Navigation

How users move through a system or interface.

Example

Using:

- menus,
- back buttons,
- or links to move between pages.

User Interface (UI)

The visible part of a system that users interact with.

Example

Buttons, menus, icons, forms, and screens.

Prototype

An early version or model of a system used for testing and evaluation.

Example

A clickable mockup of a mobile app before development.

Metaphor

A familiar real-world object or idea used to help users understand a system.

Example

A “folder” icon representing stored files.

Feedback

Information the system gives users about what is happening.

Example

A progress bar during file upload.

System Status

Information about what the system is currently doing.

Example

Showing:

- “Loading...”,

- “Saving...”,
- or “Upload Complete.”

Acceptability

How comfortable and satisfied users feel when using a system.

Example

A mobile app with a pleasant design and easy navigation is more acceptable to users.

Nielsen’s Usability Heuristics

A set of 10 usability principles created by Jakob Nielsen for evaluating interfaces.

Example

“Visibility of system status” and “Error prevention.”

Aesthetic and Minimalist Design

A design principle that says interfaces should contain only important and relevant information.

Too much information can confuse users.

Example

A clean login page with only:

- username,
- password,
- and login button.

Consistency and Standards

A usability principle that says similar actions and interface elements should behave similarly throughout the system.

Example

Using the same menu style in:

- Word,
- Excel,

- and PowerPoint.

Error Prevention

Designing the system in ways that reduce mistakes before they happen.

Example

Showing a confirmation message before deleting a file.

Flexibility and Efficiency of Use

A usability principle that supports both beginner and experienced users.

Example

Keyboard shortcuts for advanced users.

Match Between System and the Real World

A usability principle that says systems should use familiar language and concepts.

Example

Using a “trash bin” icon to represent deleting files.

Recognition Rather Than Recall

A usability principle that says users should recognize options instead of remembering information.

Example

Showing visible menu options instead of expecting users to memorize commands.

Undo and Redo

Functions that allow users to reverse or repeat actions.

Example

Undoing accidental text deletion.

User Control and Freedom

A usability principle that allows users to:

- undo actions,
- cancel operations,
- and move freely through the system.

Example

A “Back” button in a web browser.

Visibility of System Status

A usability principle that says the system should always keep users informed.

Example

Showing upload progress while a file is being uploaded.